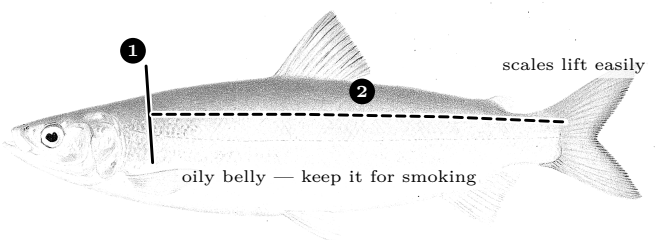


Cooking Cisco

Coregonus artedii — in the kitchen

An oily, fine-fleshed fish that wants to be smoked



Cisco from Hemlock Lake — plate from the Freshwater and Marine Image Bank, University of Washington. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	Excellent, but nothing like the others — rich, oily and fine-textured, closer to a small trout or a herring than to walleye. ●●●●○
Oil	High, and unusually so for these lakes. That is exactly why it smokes so well and why it does not keep long fresh.
Handling	The most perishable fish in the guide. Bleed it and ice it within minutes or the oil turns. This is not fussiness — a cisco left warm for two hours is not worth cooking.
Best size	10–14 in.
Yield	About 40%, the best in the guide — a straightforward, thick-bodied fish with a small head.
Season	Late autumn and through the ice, when they are at their fattest. <i>see the Cisco sheet</i>

Cleaning it

1. **Bleed it at the boat** — a cut through the gill arches — and put it straight on ice. This matters more for cisco than for anything else here.
2. **Scale it** if you are smoking or grilling skin-on. Cisco scales are large and lift with almost no effort.
3. **Gut it**, and for smoking leave the head on — it gives you something to hang it by.
4. **Or fillet normally:** behind the gill to the backbone, along the spine to the tail, ribs out. The flesh is soft, so use a sharp blade and few strokes.
5. **Leave the belly meat on.** It is the fattiest and best part, and it is what makes smoked cisco worth doing.

Bones and what to watch for

Pin bones	A row of fine pin bones runs down the fillet. Pull them with needle-nose pliers, in the direction they lean, before cooking.
Rib cage	Fine and soft.
Smoked whole	The frame lifts out in one piece after smoking — another reason to smoke rather than fillet.
Soft flesh	Handle gently and do not stack.

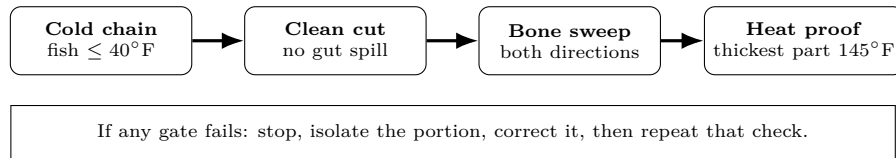
Cooking it

Method	How
Smoked	The right answer. Brine six hours in salt, brown sugar and water. Air-dry until tacky — that skin, the pellicle, is what smoke sticks to. Cold-smoke over apple or alder at 180 °F for three to four hours. Outstanding, and it keeps.
Grilled whole	Scaled, gutted, scored, oiled and salted. Hot grill, four minutes a side. The oil bastes it from inside.
Pan-fried	Fillets, skin on, skin-side down in a hot dry pan — there is enough fat in the fish that it needs almost no oil. Two minutes, flip, one minute.

The one fish here that rewards a smoker

Every other fish in this guide is lean, and lean fish smoke poorly — they go dry and stringy. Cisco is the exception, and a lake that holds them is unusual in this part of Wisconsin. If you have ever wanted a reason to build a smoker, a November cisco from Pine Lake is it. *see the **Cisco** sheet*

Prove the meal before serving



Ask now	Pass condition	If it fails
Is the fish still cold?	Firm, clean-smelling flesh at or below 40 °F.	If time above 40 °F is uncertain, discard; do not try to “cook safety back in.”
Did the knife enter gut or gall?	No green stain, fecal material, or sour odor on edible flesh.	Cut away a generous contaminated margin; wash hands, knife, and board before touching clean meat.
Are the portions actually boneless?	Bright light plus two slow fingertip passes, head-to-tail and tail-to-head.	Return the portion to the clean board; trim or recut. Never rely on batter or sauce to hide a bone.
Is the center done?	A clean instant-read probe enters sideways into the thickest piece and reads 145 °F.	Keep cooking in short increments; clean the probe before rechecking.

Final proof

Set one finished portion on a clean plate, split its thickest point, and confirm opaque, separating flakes with no translucent core. Record the time and temperature once when learning a new pan, oven, or portion thickness. Cool leftovers shallowly and refrigerate within two hours. The proof is the measured center, not a timer, crust color, or confident guess.

Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For all other species not listed as panfish: **one serving per month** for women under 50 and children under 15; **one serving per week** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR’s Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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